Subliminal Messages

By Jason Sheets

I keep trying to rationalize all that has happened, yet in the end all I can surmise is that it is over. Summer leaves, autumn falls, and winter is nature's way of saying "screw you," whisking everything away and making it appear as if nothing ever happened. I'm still not sure what did happen. I will remember the Rachel I fell in love with. I will remember our relationship in the way I had always hoped it would be. I will believe that she remembers as well. I reached out for happiness in the only way I knew how and it was within my grasp. I think. I choose to believe that.

INTRODUCTION

Sooner or later it happens to us all. The love of our life decides it's just not going to work out and takes off, leaving us feeling shattered, unlovable, abandoned, and very much alone. When it happens to you, you may believe your life can never again be the same. The pain is excruciating as are the memories. Subliminal Message by Jason Sheets

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For as long as I can remember, I have not been a memorable person. I don't think people disliked me; I just don't think they noticed me. That is until I met Rachel. When we were fourteen, our science teachers made us lab partners and somehow, maybe because she needed help in science, she noticed me. We started talking after class and meeting after school and soon enough we were friends. Now, for a fourteen year old boy, having a girl for a best friend can be a traumatic experience. Trust me. I know. It wasn't like we sat around playing dolls or anything. This was a mature relationship. We just talked-hung out, you know. We listened to each other.

After we graduated, Rachel and I still wrote. Not a lot. OK - I wrote more, but she wrote back. I want to believe she really thought about me when she wrote, the way I always thought about her when I wrote to her. I want to think she got married because she had to, she got pregnant; her father arranged it, something. I need

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to believe that she still remembered what we meant to each other.

I had always wanted more than friendship from Rachel, but I never planned on telling her. That is until Rob decided to stick his big nose in the middle of it. I am sure everyone has a friend like Rob: the one person who manages to squash your dreams while he is stepping into your life to "help out." Rob was the one who finally told Rachel the whole story. I don't know why she reacted the way she did. I expected her to laugh, to tell her husband, maybe look up my picture in the yearbook, but never, never did I expect her to call. I never expected her to ask me out.

The first date was magic. As strange as it seemed at the time, she never brought up Rob, never brought up her husband, and never stopped smiling. We talked. We danced. We reminisced. We listened to each other wonder about where our lives were headed. And then she kissed me. Fifteen years, I had been in love with the same woman, she had gotten married, I'd gotten lost, and for the first time since eighth grade

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science, we kissed. Holding her hand, her fingers hidden in my palm, I thought to myself that only a deeply crazy person would get involved with a married woman.

Oh, I was crazy. We began to meet two or three times a week. We never talked about it. We really didn't talk much. It was as if we had to spend each minute we had grasping for what we'd missed before: the years. Mostly, we never said a word. I'd pick her up at her office. We'd go back to my place. We'd make dinner. Make love. Make coffee. Sometimes she'd cry. Quietly. Then she'd ask me to take her home. I would drop her off at the corner of the block she lives on and watch her walk back home to her husband.

In the supermarket, about a month after we started the affair, I ran into Rachel- shopping with her husband. I'd never met him before, but there he was. At first, I thought I could duck into the canned goods aisle. Hide behind a Coca Cola display. But her husband caught me staring at Rachel. I smiled, looked at Rachel like I hadn't seen her since high school, and I introduced myself to her husband. And I realized, partially, as

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Rachel stared intensely at the spaghetti sauce, that she had never mentioned me before. She'd never told her husband about us growing up together. About dissecting frogs in eighth grade. About cheating in Junior French. About prom. About the letters we had written. I mean, this man had no clue who I was. And I was having an affair with his wife. Three times a week and twice on Saturday. Yet, Rachel had not even mentioned my name in passing.

The next day my crisis began. It came in the form of a note that was slipped under the door like a piece of junk mail. I recognized Rachel's handwriting immediately. The note answered questions that I had always wondered about but never really wanted answered. She told me that she was leaving her husband. She was accepting a job in Tennessee and she did not want to see me anymore. She did not tell me where she was going or how to find her.

I dropped the note and I called her office, but they just told me she had quit. My palms were starting to get wet. I tried to punch in the numbers of her home

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phone, but my finger...my finger kept slipping...slipping on the number three. Her number has three three's in a row and I couldn't get my fingers to press the numbers correctly. So I kept trying, and trying, and trying, and finally I just dropped the phone and I lost it. I don't know. The phone witch kept rambling on about hanging up and dialing again. Hang up. Dial again.

Sort of struck me as funny. Like I didn't even have an effect on anyone. The recording didn't care if I was there or not. She would keep rambling on in her smoothly corrosive voice. And I wondered if Rachel had told her husband about me before she left. I wondered what she was thinking as she studied the spaghetti jars while I introduced myself.

Now, I spend a great deal of my time writing. I write like this. I write poems. I write letters. Mostly, I write letters to Rachel. I never send them because I wouldn't know where to send them to, but I ask her a lot of questions. I have not asked her if she loved me. I haven't asked her to remember me. These two things I will wait on. I will wait until she writes me. Until then, I

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am going to assume that she did. I am going to assume that she will.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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